

BoilerFoods: Project 2 Summary

Introduction

BoilerFoods is a web application I developed to offer Purdue University students and the locals of West Lafayette an accessible means to purchase organic foods. The platform enables users to browse, review, and buy high-quality, sustainable produce, fostering a healthier community through better food choices.

Objective

My primary goal with BoilerFoods is to simplify access to organic food for my target audience by providing an easy-to-navigate online shopping experience. I aimed to create an engaging platform where customers can not only purchase but also learn about the benefits of organic produce and share their experiences with others.

Target Audience

The service is specifically tailored for Purdue University students and West Lafayette residents who prioritize health and sustainability. Recognizing their busy schedules, I designed BoilerFoods to offer a streamlined, informative, and interactive shopping experience.

Main Actions

On the BoilerFoods platform, users can:

- Explore a curated selection of organic fruits and vegetables.
- Access detailed information and reviews for each product.
- Contribute their reviews, enhancing our community's knowledge base.
- Seamlessly purchase organic goods online.

Changes from Project 1

In response to feedback from Project 1 and my ongoing analysis, I made several adjustments to improve the site's functionality and aesthetics:

1. User Interface Adaptation: I moved away from the initial Balsamiq wireframes' design to embrace a user interface that is both intuitive and visually compelling, with features like view all products button on the homepage to spotlight featured items.

2. Review Page Revamp: I significantly enhanced the "Write a Review" page to be more visually appealing and user-friendly, aiming to motivate users to share their experiences. This change, while deviating from the original wireframe, better serves the platform's community-focused vision.

3. Deferred Elements: I have postponed the addition of the BoilerFoods logo and other elements to Project 3, focusing instead on core functionalities and user experience in the current phase.

4. Incomplete Single Item Page: The development of the `single\_item.html` page remains incomplete due to the requirements for dynamic content linking and the implementation of an add-to-cart feature, which necessitates the use of JavaScript for interactive functionality. Currently, the platform directs users to a general single item page rather than providing a unique page for each product. This limitation affects the overall user experience by not allowing personalized interactions with individual products.

5. Carousel Implementation Challenges: The incorporation of a carousel feature on the homepage intended to showcase featured products dynamically also faced hurdles. My current proficiency with JavaScript is not sufficient to fully realize this feature, leading to a static representation rather than an interactive slider. This component's enhancement is critical for engaging users effectively right from the homepage.

6. Future Concepts: Throughout the semester, I'll delve into technologies like JavaScript, ReactJS, and D3.js. Gaining proficiency in these areas will allow me to create unique pages for each product, implement an add-to-cart feature, and activate the carousel functionality, which will significantly enhance the user experience on the site.

Conclusion

My development journey with BoilerFoods has transformed an idea into a functional prototype addressing my target users' needs. By prioritizing the ease of accessing organic foods and creating an interactive platform, I am dedicated to promoting a healthier lifestyle for the Purdue University community and its surroundings.

Good Software Engineering Practices

Throughout the development process, I adhered to best practices in software engineering, such as:

- Commenting code for better understanding and future maintenance.
- Employing consistent formatting to enhance code readability.
- Utilizing meaningful variable names for clarity.